

5.2.2 Behavioural Psychology

Behavioural psychologists believe that psychology should focus on observable, overt behaviour and the processes by which that behaviour has been learned. This sub-section covers conditioning and phobias as well as social learning theory and human aggression.

Phobias

Candidates should:

- demonstrate an understanding of the basic principles of classical and operant conditioning;
- be able to give a definition of a phobia and be aware of some of the more common phobias;
- understand the possible role of classical and operant conditioning in phobias e.g. the case of Little Albert;
- be aware of the limitations of the classical and operant conditioning explanations e.g. alternative causes.

Aggression

Candidates should:

- demonstrate an understanding of the basic principles of social learning theory;
- be able to describe the social learning theory explanation of human aggression;
-  consider gender and cultural differences in the level of aggression and the possible role of the media;
- be able to evaluate the social learning theory of aggression in terms of non-behavioural explanations e.g. Freud.